Trinity College Dublin
Coláiste na Tríonóide, Baile Átha Cliath
The University of Dublin

Describing Meaning
Week 8: Event Semantics

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Adverbials

Jones' activities

- Jones did it slowly.

Jones' activities

- Jones did it slowly.
- Jones did it deliberately.

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- Jones did it slowly.
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- **Jones buttered the toast.**

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A good semantics of adverbials should make these inferences unsurprising.

Two bad ideas

Could adverbials be predicates of individuals?

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Then we would need both SLOW(j) and QUICK(j) to hold of the same individual.

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Then we would need both $\text{SLOW}(j)$ and $\text{QUICK}(j)$ to hold of the same individual.

The issue is that *slowly* is not describing Jones himself; it is describing the *buttering event*.

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A second thought:

$$\text{Jones buttered the toast quickly} \rightsquigarrow \mathrm{BUTTER}(j, t, s)$$

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But this only postpones the real problem.

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That looks like the wrong way to think about verbal meaning.

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So instead of building bigger and bigger verbal relations, we let many expressions talk about one event.

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So Davidson's analysis is not just a technical trick for adverbs: it also fits the way natural language seems to talk *about* events.

Building the semantics

The basic recipe

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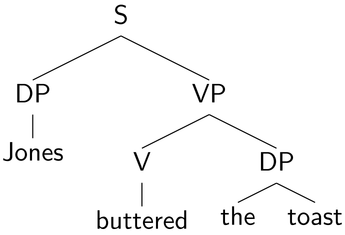
The sentence meaning is built by conjunction over one event variable:

$$\mathrm{BUTTER}(e, j, t) \wedge \mathrm{SLOW}(e) \wedge \mathrm{IN}(e, k) \wedge \mathrm{WITH}(e, n)$$

A clause with an open event variable



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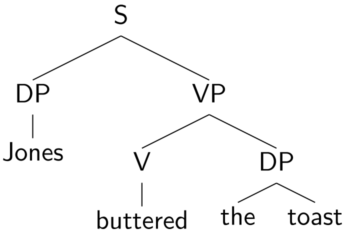

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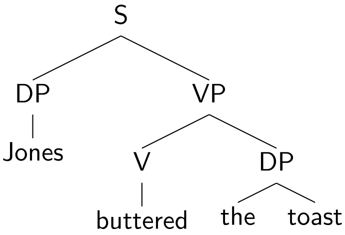

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This is not yet a proposition.
The variable e is still free.

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> *There is an event e such that e is a buttering by Jones of the toast.*

Now we have a full truth-conditional representation.

Adding a manner adverb

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Why? Because adding an adverb just adds a conjunct.

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Again, the entailments are straightforward:

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And likewise for versions with just one adjunct retained.

What this buys us

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Why this solves the adjunct problem

Event semantics helps with two central problems.

- **Composition:** adjuncts contribute ordinary predicates of events, so they can combine systematically with the clause.
- **Entailment:** adding an adjunct adds a conjunct, so the entailments to less richly modified sentences are predicted automatically.

It also avoids building implausibly large lexical entries for verbs.

Limits and complications

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These comment on the proposition from the speaker's point of view.

So the basic Davidsonian treatment is extremely useful, but not the whole story.